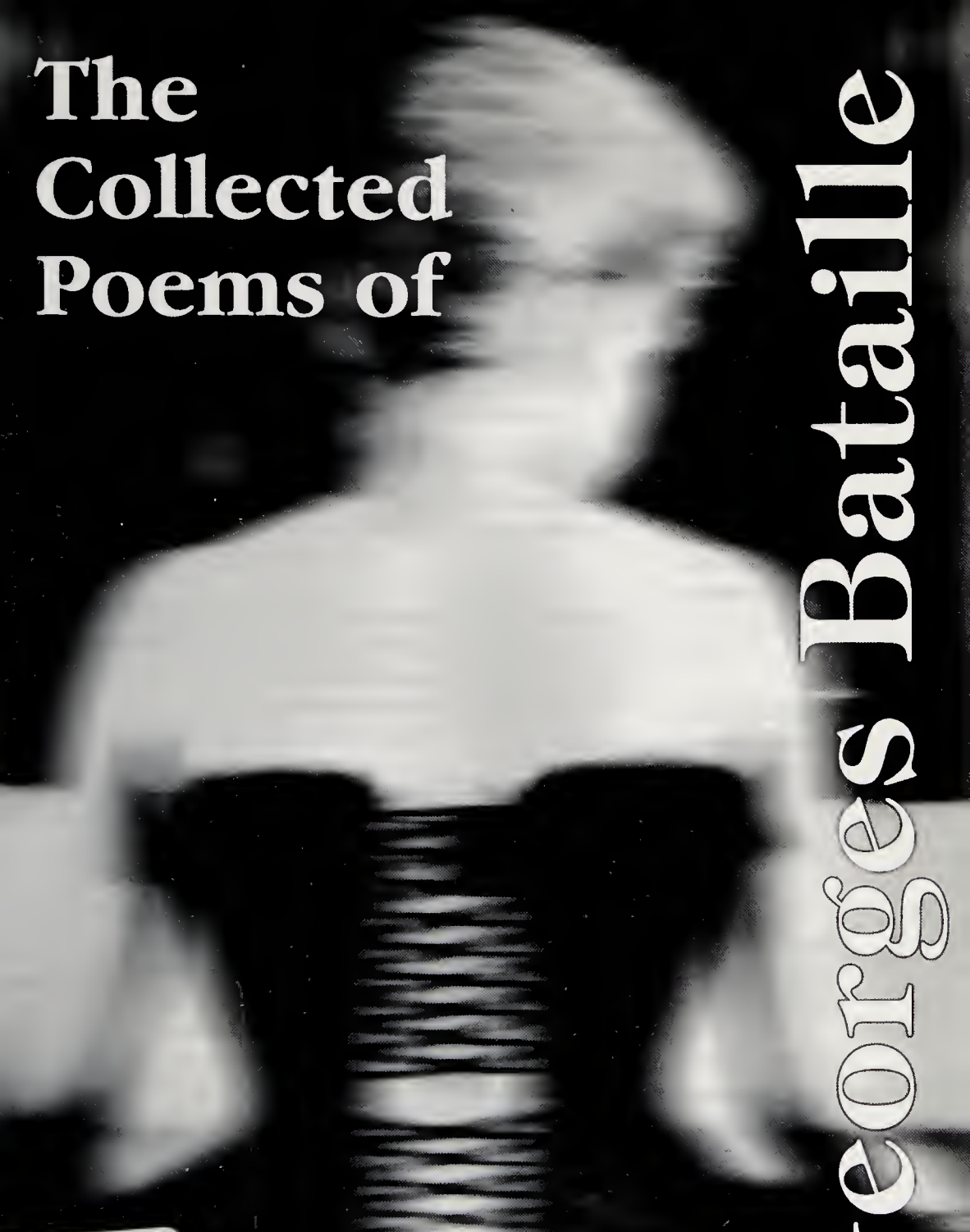
The Collected Poems of



Georges Bataille

lated

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uction by Mark Spitzer

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THE COLLECTED POEMS OF GEORGES BATAILLE

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Translated into English by Mark Spitzer

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Introduction

Georges Bataille (1897-1962) was born in Puy-Le-Dôme France, and grew up in and around Reims, the son of a blind and paralytic, syphilitic father who eventually went insane. According to Bataille, he was not a very good student and was almost expelled from high school in 1913. According to other sources, he dropped out of school in order to devote himself to Catholicism.

It's difficult to say what the actual facts are though, because our information about Bataille comes from two main sources: Bataille, and scholars who rely on what Bataille wrote about himself. Thus, the amount of fiction and exaggeration in Bataille's biographical information has not yet been determined. Whereas some speculate that Bataille became "a religious fanatic" upon his conversion in 1914, Bataille himself seems to dismiss this period as a religious phase which lasted for just a few years.

Anyway, it was during this time when Bataille and his mother abandoned his father as the Germans were advancing toward Reims. The father died soon after, and Bataille was subsequently called into service, but fell ill, so was discharged in 1917.

Bataille then went to l'Ecole des Chartes and was trained as a librarian. He spent some time in Spain, then acquired a position at the Bibliothèque Nationale where he worked for the next twenty years — writing, researching, and publishing prolifically on many subjects, including: history, religion, philosophy, architecture, art, art history, literature, sexuality, archaeology, sociology, politics, and economics.

In the meantime, Bataille also managed to become associated (as well as disassociated) with the surrealists. He and Antonin Artaud were "excommunicated" for not being in agreement with André Breton. Because of this, Bataille soon found himself speaking for a whole host of disenchanted artists and writers (including Roger Vitrac, Joan Miró, Robert Desnos, Jacques Prévert, Michel Leiris, Georges Limbour, André Masson, and more). Bataille and his disenfranchised group became known as "the rebel surrealists."

This is what Breton had to say about Bataille in his *Second Manifesto of Surrealism* (1929):

> M. Bataille professes to wish only to consider in the world that which is vilest, most discouraging, and most corrupted....In M. Bataille's case, and this is no news to anyone, what we are witnessing is an obnoxious return to old anti-dialectical materialism.[1]

Breton then goes on to imply that Bataille is an "excremental philosopher."[2] Such rants and screeds, however, were the fashion of the time. This period (from the start of World

War I to the end of World War II) was a vicious name-dropping, name-calling period. The Scottish called such banter "flyting" (in which discourse took on a poetic form), but the French called it "polemics" (in which discourse was diatribe); Breton was attacking Artaud, Artaud was attacking Breton (who was bashing Rimbaud, even though Rimbaud was dead), Sartre was condemning Céline, and Céline was condemning everyone. Differences in use of language, philosophical standpoints, positions on fascism, and even attitudes toward *nonsense* worked as convenient occasions for contemporary thinkers to argue about the validity of the intellectual niches they had carved for themselves.

Meanwhile, numerous literary journals in France were devoted to slander and defamation of character, Marx and Freud had become adjectives, and letters were being read aloud in cafés listing those who belonged to the club, and those who didn't. To sum things up, it was a battle between (and a combination of) Dadaist-Surrealism, Existentialism, Cubism, and the Theater of the Absurd.

Bataille, however, was highly influential during this time. His literary journals (*Documents*, *Acéphale* and *Critique*) were widely read by the avant-garde as well as the public, and his essays frequently caused a reaction (especially those promoting orgiastic ecstacy and furious rebellion). Consequently, many of Bataille's concepts were addressed by his colleagues and their students, most notably: Maurice Blanchot, Roland Barthes, Jacques Derrida, and Jean Baudrillard. Michel Foucault, however, was the most impressed, as he indicates in

his introduction to Bataille's *Œuvres*, refering to Bataille as "one of the most important writers of our century."[3]

Bataille is generally noted for two important contributions to western literature. First of all, he wrote *Histoire de l'œil* (*Story of the Eye*), which had a profound effect on literary France (and thus the world) following its publication in 1928. *Story of the Eye* was regarded as a pornographic novel which made its point by pushing the taboo, thus making sexuality "erotic."[4]

But Bataille is also known for "his philosophy" (to generalize it), which was a nouveau-nihilistic Nietzschean interpretation of Hegel, Marx, and Sade, combined with an erotic indulgence that 20th century bourgeois philosophers had a hard time accepting — even though the surrealist movement supposedly relied heavily on the scatological delvings of Freudian interpretation.[5] For the most part, Bataille's theories were so explicit, and his examples were so nakedly graphic, that much of what he presented was considered inappropriate, even to the Académie Française. Which is pretty amazing, considering the French tendency to passionately confront and then appropriate the "socially unacceptable," thus heralding criminals, drug addicts, and the "sexually deviant" as their greatest poets.

Hence, the question that remains today is this: Did Bataille have something to say, or was he just trying to be shocking? Foucault and Barthes, no doubt, would agree that Bataille was a genius. Breton and Sartre, however, would most likely argue

that Bataille was showing off. The debate continues to this day.

* * *

The poetry of Georges Bataille is definitely the poetry of a philosopher. There are certain themes — *the immensity, the impossible, the void, desire, nothingness* — which keep cropping up in his verse. These are themes which have been defined in previous works by Bataille, but take on a different form in poetry where they are presented to the audience through an aloof, abstract confidence which doesn't seem to always make sense.

This is because Bataille's poems have never really been put into context. That is, without any explanation of where Bataille was coming from, or where he was going with his poetry, his poems risk falling into that category which is sometimes referred to as "intellectual masturbation." Thus, the purpose of what follows is to provide some background on the poems in order to place them into context.

Bataille started working on his poetry later in life. Most of his poems were written (and published in various reviews) between 1942 and 1957. Some poetry was published in *L'Expérience intérieure* (1943) and *Sur Nietzsche* (1945). The brunt of his poetry, however, was conceived and written during World War II. *Haine de la poèsie* (*The Hatred of Poetry*) was first published in 1947, and contained a section called "L'Orestie," which was verse. These poems, as well as

L'Archangélique et autre poèmes (Mercure de France, 1967) were essentially received with indifference. Nobody really knew what to make of Bataille's poetry. Except, that is, for Jacques Chatain, who wrote a book which was published by Éditions Seghers in 1973. In this book, Chatain uses the poetry of Bataille to show how Bataille relates his poetics to his aesthetics.

And rightly so. Poetry, for Georges Bataille, was the practice of "his philosophy" (again I use the term loosely). Basically, Bataille believed that poetry was a mode by which one could actually transcend nature and become a Zarathustrian superman. Take these lines from *Haine de la poèsie* for example:

> If I did not exceed nature, in a leap beyond "the static and the given," I would be defined by laws. But nature *plays me*, casting me further than herself, beyond the laws, the limits that make *humble people* love her...
>
> Were I to rave, I would be *merely natural*.... Poetic delirium has its place in *nature*.[6]

For Bataille, the idea of attaining poetry (or "exceeding" nature), had to do with *the impossible*. According to Bataille, *the impossible* is "what can't be grasped in any way, what we can't reach without dissolving ourselves."[7]

Hence, *Haine de la poèsie* was later renamed *L'Impossible*, which is referential to Arthur Rimbaud. Bataille was con-

vinced that Rimbaud had achieved the *possible* (which, of course, is the conquering of *the impossible*), so no wonder Bataille aspired to a similar *derangement of the senses* in order to reach his own visionary goal: an ethereal, omnipotent voice charged by poetic lyricism.

But Bataille is tricky. In the "Preface" to the second edition of *L'Impossible*, he writes this about achieving *the impossible*: "Indeed I think that in a sense my narratives clearly attain the *impossible*."[8] But then, later on, he seemingly contradicts himself, refusing to let the reader believe he made it as far as he had previously implied, in any sense: "I approach poetry: but only miss it."[9]

Thus spoke Bataille. But why?

Well... *the impossible* is ultimately impossible — but still, Bataille suggests a space in the vicinity of *the impossible* which can be reached through poetry: "Poetry removes one from the night and the day at the same time."[10] And in this space (which is as close as one can get to *the impossible*) the results of *the impossible* are experiencable, at least *temporarily*. And since the main result of experiencing *the impossible* is virtual non-existence, Bataille states:

> Poetry was simply a detour: through it I escaped the world of discourse, which had become the natural world for me; with poetry I entered a kind of grave where the infinity of the possible was born from the death of the logical world.[11]

This is exactly what Jean-Paul Sartre objected to in the attitude of Bataille. In *Situations, 1* (1947), Sartre makes the point: "Bataille wonders how to express silence with words... moreover, he regrets the use of discourse. He hates it, and through it, all language."[12]

But there's a difference between an escape from language and an escape from logic. Bataille was not trying to escape language, he was employing it in an appreciative way, to escape a *sense*less "beingness," which is reflected in the beings who bump against each other in his poetry:

> Deserting a sky distorting the being
> empty voice tongue heavy with coffins
> being bumping against being
> the head conceals the being
> the sickness of the being vomits a black sun of spit.
>
> (from "Oh Cranium...")

This is where "erotic nature" comes in. Not only did Bataille believe that everything relates to the workings of desire and death in sexuality, but he also believed that poetry was the product of "hate" (and other extreme emotions), just as much as erotic pleasure accedes to self-annihilation. Take this line-of-thought, for example, from *Erotism: Death and Sensuality*:

> The domain of eroticism is the domain of violence, of violation... a violation bordering on death, bordering on murder?... The whole business of eroticism is to strike to the inmost core of the living being, so that the heart stands still.[13]

This viewpoint, of course, points to Bataille's lurid fascination with Gilles de Rais, Jean Genet, the Marquis de Sade, and all that is commonly considered "horrible" in human nature. Bataille was interested in actual action, not just disengaged hypothesis concerning the sexual act. Gilles de Rais, for Bataille, bypassed moral and social constraints by merging desire and death in one single act (the act of slaughtering/sodomizing little boys). And Genet, of course (who, incidentally, stole an original manuscript from Bataille), was the legendary criminal *écrivain* who held "betrayal" as the deepest form of desire a person could express.[14]

Such inner experiences, however, were hardly ironic for Bataille. They were *truths*. And the blending of these *truths* (*erotic truths*) can be seen in Bataille's most discorporated moments:

non-love is truth
and everything lies in the absence of love
nothing exists which does not lie

compared to non-love
love is cowardly
and does not love

love is a parody of non-love
truth a parody of the lie
the universe a gay suicide

(from "The Archangelical")

Hence, there is *sense* in Bataille's *non-sense* — which is his verse. So for those who are familiar with Bataille's prose, there will no doubt be connections in these poems. But for those who are not familiar with Bataille's prose, the emotive forces in his poetry can still produce a strong *sense* for what he is expressing. Bataille wrote his poetry to be understood, as well as felt:

> We all feel what poetry is....Poetry leads to the same place as all forms of eroticism — to the blending and fusion of separate objects. It leads us to eternity, it leads us to death, and through death to continuity. Poetry is eternity; the sun matched with the sea.[15]

* * *

Matching English to French, however, is another story. There are always those who claim that poetic translations are impossible, that meaning is lost, and sound is lost, and song is lost, when a translator takes an author's work in one language and interprets it into another. I do not hold to this school.

Yes, a translation always involves a sacrifice, but still, one can get as close as one can get to the original idea, which is the most a translation can hope for. In other words, *the impossible* is possible, in translation as well as poetry, if the standards one sets can be met. The true test of whether or not a translation works, however, can only be felt on an individual basis, depending on whether or not an individual feels anything worth feeling when experiencing a translation.

For the most part, the following poems are literal-based translations in which I've tried to stick with the syllable-sounds Bataille left behind. I've also tried to take as few translating liberties as possible while remaining faithful to what Bataille was trying to say. Sometimes, however, I couldn't remain loyal to his exact language, which often calls attention to itself in French, though if I did this in English, the emphasis would be lost. However, there are instances where I did keep Bataille's out-of-grammarness intact.

But the major problem in translating the poetry of Bataille (as in translating any poetry), is what to do with multiple meanings. Bataille's language is elusive. These poems contain archaic idioms as well as popular argot; there are words that are verbs and modifiers at the same time; and some words have more than just a couple functions.

So this is what I did: I chose to pick the most workable solutions in the English language, except in a few isolated instances where alternative views are offered in the "Miscellaneous Notes on the Text" section in the back of the book. Nevertheless, if someone seeks out the original French, and if this person is familiar with Bataille (or translating French), then more translation possibilities than exist in this text will of course be discovered. This is the way Bataille meant it to be. His poems are flexible, meaning that they can accommodate different visions, and not just because they are ambiguous or difficult to interpret but, rather, because they contain (to borrow from Whitman) multitudes. Multitudes of possible possibles.

For example, here's a stanza which possesses many possibilities:

JE penché sur la caisse
JE ai
mon envie de vomir envie

The literal translation of this would be:

I bent over the case
I have
my desire to vomit desire

Or, to be more idiomatic about it:

I bent over the case
I want
to vomit want

The verb "envier" can refer to many different kinds of envy. It could mean "yearn for," "long for," "wish for," "crave," "covet," or any other form of desire. And it does. The use of "envie" encompasses all of these meanings. And not only that, but Bataille sometimes plays around with the last "envie," changing it to "en vie" (meaning "in life" or "living").

And then there's the noun "caisse," which could also mean

"box," "chest," "coffer," "till," or "cash register." Though in my translations I prefer "crate," considering the context that "la caisse" is used in: it contains false teeth, and is manufactured like "nothingness" in the "factory of infinite vanity" (see "I Hurl Myself among the Dead").

Then, to further confuse things, there's the less visible context of the stanza. When spoken in French, the grammatically strange "JE ai" sounds like "JE hais," which translates into "I hate."

I mention this poem in particular because it is Bataille's most chaotic poem, and it illustrates how *flexible* his poetry can be, which is an unusual quality in any language. Not that there haven't been other French poets who have done the same thing, but there certainly haven't been many who have done it to the degree that Bataille did.

Another reason I mention this poem is because it brings up a theme (*nausea of desire*) which keeps coming back, almost as much as the stanza itself. Bataille was a notorious self-plagiarizer. He often dismantled and dismembered his own poems, then reconstructed them later. Bataille was a recycler of his own poetry. My use of the word "recycle," however, should not be taken as a judgmental view. Recycling lines of poetry, for Bataille, meant plugging his re-usable thoughts into new cycles (or directions) of thought. Thus, this collection reflects a few instances of recycling, which is unavoidable when compiling a book of poems by Bataille.

I should also note that the poems in this book were collected from the *Œuvres* by Éditions Gallimard, and *L'Archangélique et autre poèmes* by Mercure de France, and compromise 90-something percent of Bataille's known poems. The remainder of Bataille's poems were unobtainable at the time the English language rights for this book were acquired, due to complications with availability and accessibility. Concerning availability, permission could not be acquired to publish some of the poems which have already appeared in *Sur Nietzsche*, which was translated by Bruce Boone. As for accessibility, there are quite a few Bataille poems still out there fading away in obscure French literary journals, which were unavailable during the research for this book. And then there are the occasional poems which appear sporadically in Bataille's fiction and nonfiction. I note this in order to make clear that whereas *The Collected Poems of Georges Bataille* is the most complete collection of Bataille poems to ever be assembled, it nevertheless does not reflect the entire collection of his verse.

This is, however, the first book-length collection of Bataille's poetry to exist in the English language. Bataille's poetry has been overlooked for decades, but not because it is one of his less important genres. It could be that the verse of this "excommunicated surrealist" was delayed for reasons having to do with what Breton and the mainstream surrealists considered appropriate, or it could be for a general lack of interest in what Bataille held as too personal an art to exploit during his lifetime. But I won't speculate any further on these possibilities, except to add that Bataille's poetry did make an

impact, if not on literature at the time, then at least on those surrealists effected by the ideas in his verse.

Notes

1. André Breton, *Manifestoes of Surrealism*, trans. Richard Seaver and Helen R. Lane, (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1969), pp. 181-183.

2. In the "Second Manifesto of Surrealism" (André Breton, *Manifestoes of Surrealism*, p. 185), Breton refers to Bataille through this footnote:

> In his *Différence de la philosophie de la nature chez Democrite et Epicure*, Marx tells us how, in every age, there thus come into being hair-philosophers, fingernail-philosophers, toenail-philosophers, excrement-philosophers, etc.

3. Michel Foucault, *Œuvres complètes de Georges Bataille*, vol. I (Paris: Éditions Gallimard, 1970), p. 5.

4. In *Michel Foucault: Social Theory and Transgression*, (New York: Columbia University Press, 1982, p. 66), Charles C. Lemert and Garth Gillan note what many scholars have noted about Bataille, including Bataille himself: "For Bataille, eroticism arises when sexuality crosses the limits erected by the taboo on sexuality."

5. In the "Second Manifesto of Surrealism" (pp. 159,160), Breton professes:

> It is incumbent on us... to try to see more and more clearly what is transpiring unbeknownst to man in the depths of his mind... Surrealism believes Freudian criticism to be the first and only one with a really solid basis.

6. Georges Bataille, *The Impossible*, trans. Robert Hurley, (San Francisco: City Lights Books, 1991), pp. 157,158.

7. Georges Bataille, *Guilty*, trans. Bruce Boone, (San Francisco: The Lapis Press, 1988), p. 139.

8. Georges Bataille, *The Impossible*, trans. Robert Hurley, (San Francisco: City Lights Books, 1991), p. 9.

9. *Ibid.*, p. 159.

10. *Ibid.*, p. 159.

11. *Ibid.*, p. 163.

12. Joseph Halpern, *Critical Fiction: The Literary Criticism of Jean-Paul Sartre*, (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1976), p. 20.

13. Georges Bataille, *Erotism: Death & Sensuality*, trans. Mary Dalwood, (San Francisco: City Lights Books, 1986), pp. 16,17.

14. See Edmund White, *Genet: A Biography*, (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1993), p. 398.

15. Georges Bataille, *Erotism: Death & Sensuality*, trans. Mary Dalwood, (San Francisco: City Lights Books, 1986), p. 25.

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— *Mark Spitzer,*
Lafayette, Louisiana,
1998

Grief

Grief
grief
grief
oh grief
oh grief
oh my tears of sap
my saffron dick

oh to pull down my pants
and piss myself.

Mademoiselle My Heart

Mademoiselle my heart
placed naked in lace
with a perfumed mouth
pee flowing down her legs

The cosmetic scent of her slit
is left to the heavenly wind

a cloud
in the head

is reflected in reverse
a marvelous star
falls
heart crying like a mouth

the heart fails
a lily is burning
throat opened by the sun.

Pee

Magpie devouress of stars
fatigue devouress of earth
the exhaustion of all

rapacious sky
cursed sky
patron of the hospital

a raven on stilts
goes into the eye

flaming ruby heart
pee on my naked thigh
shiny wet behind
I get hard and I cry

black wing of the grave
politeness of the crypt.

With Romaine

With romaine
a heart of veal

a pointy beard
and the rosy nut.

Laughing

To laugh and laugh
at the sun
at the nettles
at the pebbles
at the ducks

at the rain
at the pope's pee
at mommy
and a coffin full of shit.

I Place my Cock...

I place my cock against your cheek
the tip brushes your ear
lick my balls slowly
your tongue is soft like water

your tongue is as raw as a butcheress
it is as red as a leg of lamb
its tip is a coo-coo bird crying out
my cock sobs with saliva

your bottom is my goddess
it opens like your mouth
I worship it like the sky
I venerate it like a fire

I drink from your gash
I spread your naked legs
I open them like a book
where I read what kills me.

Oh Cranium...

Oh cranium anus of the empty night
the sky blows away what dies
the wind brings absence to obscurity

Deserting a sky distorting the being
empty voice tongue heavy with coffins
being bumping against being
the head conceals the being
the sickness of the being vomits a black sun of spit.

Shirt pulled off in the water
blooming with hairs
when filthy happiness licks the lettuce
heart sick in the rain
in the vacillating light of drool she laughs blissfully.

Eleven Poems Taken from the Archangelical

My madness and my fear
have wide dead eyes
and the steady gaze of fever

what looks in these eyes
is the nothingness of the universe
my eyes are blind skies

in my impenetrable night
the impossible cries out
everything crumbles



Almanac of inky lye
immortality of a hairy poet
poetry cemetery of obesity

farewell lewd washerwomen
farewell sweet dead dressed up like naked women

farewell lies farewell sleep



infinite itching of ants arrest
sorting papers moustaches in dust
wagonloads of fever

column of mad rain
clappings of soiled shrouds
funereal immodesty of human bones

there's a crowd piling up cans of maybe
a gendarme in a shirt on top of a roof
waves a scythe the Demon



I lose you in the wind
I count you among the dead
a vital cord
between heart and wind



I have nothing to do in this world
except burn
I love you unto death

your restlessness
a mad wind whistles in your head
you are sick from laughing
you flee me for a bitter void
tearing your heart apart

tear me apart if you like
my fever-burned eyes
find you in the night



I am cold in the heart I tremble
from the depths of my pain I call to you
with an inhuman cry
as if I were giving birth

you strangle me like death
I know this miserably
I only find you in the throes of death
you are as beautiful as death

all words strangle me



star pierce the sky
scream like death
strangle

I don't want life
it is sweet to be strangled
the rising star
is as cold as a dead woman



blindfold my eyes
I love the night
my heart is black

push me into the night
all is false
I suffer

the world smells like death
birds fly blindly
you are as dark as a black sky



the feast will commence
in mud and fear

stars will fall
when death comes near



You are the horror of night
my love for you is like a cry of death
you are weak like death

my love for you is like delirium
you know my head dies
you are the immensity the fear

you are beautiful like murder
my heart expands enormously I choke
your belly is naked like the night



You lead me straight to the end
the death throes have begun
I have nothing more to tell to you
I speak to you from the dead
and the dead are silent

ELIMINATED POEMS

The Houses

Ten a hundred houses fall
a hundred then a thousand dead
in the window of the sky

an empty sorrow
row of shadows
this night stretches out and chokes

the eyes of these dead
exhaust the heart
blind voiceless head
insanity without being.



Even unto the hole of the stars
even unto a night of ink
even unto the lackluster eye
even unto a great silence
even unto the haunted castle of memory
even unto a madwoman's cry
even unto anguish even unto the grave

even unto the dawn of my death.



The Charnel House

The strength of life and the misery of cold
the hard stupidity of man
knowing the law of his knife
head stingy for ecstacy

a heart of ice a steaming soup
a blood-stained foot
the moustache of tears
a death rattle.



The Wall

A hatchet
give me a hatchet
so I can frighten myself
with my shadow on the wall
ennui
feeling of emptiness
fatigue.



The Church Square

Nightcap
chamber pot
a red stocking a set of dentures

golden miter
frozen sky
eating the lights
of the perched cat.



Endless visage
of God
that gentleman
and his lady
etc.
it kills me
and you.



The Castle

My small sufferings at night
tore me apart
torn into great ruins
on the summit of a bald rock

a crumbling high wall
scales the dark sky
raising the dead stone
of a terrifying tower.



The Hoarfrost

My lover death
star of living lime
heart of ice heart of water
heart with hoarfrost hair
star of ash
silence without lips.



The Window

Little bird
a thousand colors
a death fills the sky

a flat crow
dead eyes
the wind tears out the sky

whisperings
of a dead woman
madness opens the sky.



Mass of earth in the sky
silence sign of nothingness
grassy drowsy yellowed mountain
fall of the being in the night

I hide myself within your shadows
and I eat at your sun
my skeleton is transparent
in the light of day

a feeling of terror
gently squeezes the throat
it slowly freezes the heart.



The Sun

I love the ash the slag
a head of hard stone
and the insistence of my life

purplish hands
laughter in the cold
and the red knife of teeth.



The Seminary

Thirty black souls
jawbones frozen
thirty black donkeys
jawbones skinned

a dead star
sings a psalm the *Miserere*
a dead mouth
spits a soul the *Miserere*

a donkey sky
sneezes a cry
of fear
in which my soul
spat the cry of the heart.



Laughter of birds bloody mud
shattering of ice of teeth
filth scream vomiting
head lowered in the horror.



Earth spin spin earth
spinning goddamn woods
red sun black sun
white roses pink roses

roses of the grave
spinning roses
goddamn graves
spinning graves.



Cracked skull
city in flames

sky of soot
hairy woman

the skinned rabbit's
dripping nose.



The Mask

Death masked in wax paper
to flee the excess of this silence
to amuse the stench.



The Church

Icy winter wind
oh my dying sister
gleam of wolf bite of hunger
frozen stone flush against the naked heart

ah indifferent spit
ah sky insulting to all hearts
ah cold emptier than death.



The Wolf Sighs...

The wolf sighs tenderly
sleep beauty of the manor
the wolf was crying like a child
never will you know my pain
the wolf was crying like a child

She laughed at her lover
the wind moans in an ancient oak
the wolf died crying blood
his bones dried upon the plain
the wolf died crying blood.

EROTIC POEMS

Insignificance

I put to sleep
the needle
of my heart
I cry
over a word
that I lost
I open
the brim
of a tear
where the dead
dawn
is silent.



Morning Twilight

I erase
the footstep
I erase
the word
and space
and breath
are missing.



The Earth

The dead man
catches the quick

and the bird brings up the rear.



The Washing

The moon
is the soap
of the shrill pipes
of my voice.



I spread the legs
with the beef tongue
of fur

A long penis spat
in the chapel of my heart.



my asshole is the altar
and the altarcloth is the toilet



The dead sun was illuminating the hairy shadow
with a trail of bitter sperm
the head of your tongue with eyes of blood.



swollen like a dick my tongue
in your throat of pink love.

My vulva is my butchery
red blood awash in sperm
sperm swimming in blood.

In my mauve stockings the apple scent
the pantheon of the majestic cock
the ass of a bitch open
to the holiness of the street.

the long-haired love of my leg
a pantheon of sperm.

I sleep
mouth open in expectation
of a dick choking me
with a bland and sticky spurt.

The ecstacy buttfucking me is the marble
of the cock smeared with blood.

To surrender myself to the pricks
I put on my dress
which cleaves the soul.



The bird
of the woods

and the solitude
of the forest.



The Lightning

The cannon thunders in the body
and the lightning in the bronze eye
has the nudity of filth.

Solitude

Thumb in cunt
Eucharist upon your naked breasts
my ass soils the altarcloth
my mouth implores Oh Christ
the charity of your thorn.

Sleepless Night

To choke
to stunt a voice
to swallow the tongue while dying
to abolish the noise
to go to sleep
to shave
to laugh ecstatically.

Black Night

Thou shalt mock thy neighbor as thyself

Tear love from the goose
from the spleen of great men

Oblivion is the friendship of the massacred man

With all due respect
I go.

The Tolling

In my voluptuous bell
the bronze of death dances
the clapper of a penis sounds
a long libidinous tolling

The Bald Man

Your penis-hole is the laughter
and its balls are the dawn.

Coryphea

Oh Tragedy! blood spills from my breasts, my throat opens itself to death, with a wicked cooing... I give my life up to the cunning smiles of pleasure: it is the intoxicating smell of money. Let one final embrace adorn your loins in the gluey dress of death.

My Song

I fill the sky with my presence
My cry is not that
of a great bird
piercing the dawn
my song is not that
of cicadas filling the summer nights
my lament is not that
of dying people in the void
that follows a bombing
it rends the flesh
I do not die I am nothing
don't I know what this scream is
It opens the clouds
I do not laugh
never do I cry
I howl
I open the sky
like we open the throats
of the dying
I am calm
like a bull
lowing in the rain
I am not a man

I moo
I am stupider than lightning
bursting with laughter
I want to raise a ruckus
so great
that no one will be able
to hear anything
anymore.

The *Marseillaise* of Love

Two naked lovers sing the *Marseillaise*
two bloody kisses bite their heart
horses run full-speed ahead
horsemen dead
village abandoned
a child cries
in the never-ending night.

The Brown Waltz

The Chameleon
holds the accordion
guitar
your string breaks
wedding full of murk
and the waltz dies
to the singing of the *Libera Nos*.

It's the Newest Dance

When the she-asses die
of cholera
their sob
will be a widow's sob
and the widow
will dream of her loves
weep! weep!
till the end of the world
dream! dream!
of our loves deceased
it is not time to bray
today
but tomorrow
all the donkeys of the world
will dance the cholera.

[The Sidewalk of Danaïde]

My whore
my heart
I love you like we shit
Soak your ass in the storm
surrounded by lightning
The thunderbolt screws you
a madman bellows in the night
hardening like a stag
Oh death I am that stag
devoured by the dogs
Death ejaculates blood.

THE ARCHANGELICAL

The Tomb

I

Criminal immensity
cracked vase of the immensity
ruin without end

flabby immensity weighing me down
I am limp
the universe is guilty

winged madness my madness
rips open the immensity
and the immensity rips me

I am alone
some blind men will read these lines
in never-ending tunnels

I am falling into the immensity
which falls into itself
it is blacker than my death

the sun is black
the beauty of a being is the depth of cellars
a cry of the definitive night

the desire of the night
loves in the light
the shiver which freezes it

I lie
and the universe affixes itself
to my insane lies

the immensity
and I
denounce the lies of each other

truth dies
and I cry
that truth lies

my sugary head
worn out by fever
is the suicide of truth

non-love is truth
and everything lies in the absence of love
nothing exists which does not lie

compared to non-love
love is cowardly
and does not love

love is a parody of non-love
truth a parody of the lie
the universe a gay suicide

in non-love
the immensity falls within itself
not knowing what to do

in peace everything is for everyone
the worlds turn majestically
in their calm monotony

the universe is within me as it is within itself
nothing separates us anymore
I bump against it in myself

in the infinite calm
where laws enchain it
it glides toward the impossible
immensely

horror
of a world turning in circles
the object of desire is farther away

the glory of man
no matter how great
is to desire another glory

I am
the world is with me
pushed outside the possible

I am only the laughter
and the infantile night
where the immensity falls

I am the dead man
the blind man
the airless shadow

like rivers in the sea
in me noise and light
lose themselves endlessly

I am the father
and the tomb
of the sky

the excess of darkness
is the flash of the star
the cold of the grave is a die

rolled by death
and the depths of the heavens jubilate
for the night which falls within me.

II

Time oppresses me I fall
and I slide on my knees
my hands feel the night

farewell streams of light
all that remains for me is the shadow
the dregs the blood

I await the strike of the bell
where screaming
I entered the shadow.

III

A long bare foot upon my mouth
a long foot against the heart
you are my thirst my fever

foot of whisky
foot of wine
foot mad to smash

oh my horse-whip my pain
very high heel smashing me
I cry from not dying

oh thirst
unquenchable thirst
inescapable desert

sudden gust of death in which I scream
blind on both knees
eye-sockets empty

corridor where I laugh at an insane night
corridor where I laugh in the slamming of doors
where I worship an arrow

and I burst in sobs
the trumpet blast of death
bellows in my ear.

IV

Beyond my death
one day
the earth spins in the sky

I am dead
and the darkness
alternates forever with the day

the universe is shut to me
within it I remain blind
bound to nothingness

the nothingness is only myself
the universe is only my grave
the sun is only death

my eyes are blind lightning
my heart is the sky
bursting with storm

in myself
at the bottom of an abyss
the immense universe is death

I am the fever
the desire
I am the thirst

and the joy taking off your dress
and the wine making you laugh
from not being dressed anymore

in a bowl of gin
a night of festivity
stars falling from the sky

I guzzle down lightning in great gulps
I will burst with laughter
lightning in my heart.

The Dawn

Spit the blood
it is the dew
the saber by which I will die

from the edge of the well
look the starry sky
has the transparency of tears

I find you in the star
I find you in death
you are the frost of my mouth
you smell like a dead woman

your breasts open like a coffin
and laugh at me from the beyond
your two long thighs rave crazily
your belly is as naked as a wail of death

you are beautiful like fear
you are mad like a dead woman

the unhappiness in unnameable
the heart is a grimace

what curdles in the milk
is the mad laughter of death

a star has risen
you are I am the void
a star has risen
as painful as the heart

gleaming like a tear
you whistle it is death
the star fills the sky
as painful as a tear

I know that you don't love
but the rising star
sharp as death
exhausts and twists the heart

I am cursed voila! my mother
what a long night it is
my long tearless night

night greedy for love
oh broken heart of stone
the hell of my mouth of ash

you are the death of tears
curse you
my cursed heart my sick eyes search for you

you are the void and the ash
headless bird with wings that beat the night
the universe is made from your little hope

the universe is your sick heart and mine
beating and just brushing death
in the cemetery of hope

my pain is the joy
and the ash the fire

tooth of hatred
you are damned
whoever is damned will pay

you will pay your share of hate
you will bite the horrible sun
he who is damned bites the sky

with me you will rend
your heart loved by fright
your being strangled by ennui

you are the friend of the sun
there is no rest for you
your fatigue is my madness

from dung in the head
I burst I hate the sky
who am I to spit out heavens
it is bitter to be immense
my eyes are fat pigs
my heart is black ink
my sex is a dead sun

stars fallen in a bottomless pit
I cry and my tongue flows
it hardly matters that immensity is round
and rolls in a guillotine basket
I love death I invite it
in the Butchery of Holy Father

black death you are my bread
I eat you in the heart
terror is my tenderness
there's madness in my hand

to knot the noose of the hanged man
with the teeth of a dead horse

Softness of water
rage of wind

burst of laughter from the star
morning of beautiful sun

there's nothing I don't dream
there's nothing I don't scream

farther away than tears death
higher than the bottom of the sky

in the space between your breasts

limpid from head to toe
fragile like the dawn
the wind has broken the heart

with the hardness of anguish
the black night is a church
where they're slitting the throat of a pig

trembling from head to toe
fragile like death
my big sister agony

you are colder than the earth

you will recognize happiness
when you see it die

your sleep and your absence
join in the grave

you are the heartbeat
I listen to beneath my ribs
and the breath held in

my sobs on your knees
I will shake the night

shadow of wings on a field
my lost child heart

my laughing sister you are death
the heart fails you are death
in my arms you are death

we have drunk you are death
like the wind you are death
like lightning death

death laughs death is joy

alone you are my life
lost sobs
separate me from death
I see you through tears
and I foresee my death

if I did not love death
my suffering
and desire for you
would kill me

your absence
your distress
make me nauseous
it's time for me to love death
it's time to bite its hands

to love is to agonize
to love is to love dying
monkeys reek as they die

enough I wish I were dead
I am too limp for that
enough I am tired

enough I love you like a nut
I laugh at myself the ass of ink
braying to the stars of the sky

naked you were bursting with laughter
gigantic beneath the canopy
I grovel in order not to be anymore

I desire to die from you
I want to annihilate myself
within your sick whims.

The Void

Flames surrounded us
beneath our footsteps the abyss opened up
a silence of milk of frost of bones
was shrouding us with a halo

you are the transfigured
my destiny has broken your teeth
your heart is a hiccup
your fingernails have found the void

you speak like laughter
the winds make your hair stand on end
the anguish wringing the heart
precipitates your mockery

your hands behind my head
only grasp death
your laughing kisses only open
to my hellacious poverty

beneath the sordid canopy
where bats hang
your marvelous nudity
is only a tearless lie

my cry calls to you in the desert
where you don't want to come
my cry calls to you in the desert
where your dreams will come true

your mouth sealed to mine
and your tongue in my teeth
death immense will welcome you
night immense will fall

so then in your abandoned head
I will have made a void
your absence will be naked
like a stockingless leg

while awaiting the disaster
of the lights going out
I will be soft in your heart
like the cold of death.

The Tomb of Louis XXX

the dregs
the exhaustion of a hideous heart
the acrid
the sweet intimacy of vice

the *SKY* inverted in your eyes.



Wind tomb
river tomb

my death fakes my voice
which can only reach

to the ache of teeth

little flower
little ear you know
to what point
I am afraid of shit.



At night
to watch the sky
with the crack of your ass.



The wound is fresh
it disfigures
the red streams out
the gash gets hard

there is no more eye
it is me.

THE ORATORIO

CHARACTERS

The Narrator.

The Whore, 90 years old, dying (she was adorably beautiful at 20; one day when she was naked she did for God what Aurcourt does for Duclos in *120 Days*).

The Priest, 30 years old.

God, a sort of paving stone.

The Narrator names and presents the characters. There are no costumes nor scenery. The scene takes place in the bedroom of the whore.

She says:

To the sewer
I am the sewer
alas!

Herr Priest says:

I am Herr Priest
your little boy
caress my ear
while you die.
Oh my host
my sewer mother
I raise you into the sky

the paving stone says:

I am God
I conk you on the head
Herr Priest
I kill you
I am an idiot.

Oresteia

Oresteia
dew from the sky
bagpipe of life

spidered night
of innumerable hauntings
relentless play of tears
oh sun in my breast long sword of death

rest along my bones
rest you are the lightning
rest viper
rest my heart

the rivers of love blush pink with blood
the winds have undone my assassin hair

Chance oh pale goddess
laughter of lightning
invisible sun
thundering in the heart
naked chance

chance with long white stockings
chance with a lacy nightgown on.

Myself

Heart eager for glimmer
belly stingy for caresses
false sun false eyes
words carriers of plague

the earth loves cold bodies.

Tears of frost
ambiguity of eyelashes

lips of a dead woman
unatonable teeth

absence of life

nudity of death.

Through lies, indifference, the chattering of teeth, insane happiness, and certainty,

in the bottom of the well, tooth to the tooth of death, a minute particle of blinding life is born from an accumulation of waste,

I flee it, it insists; injected, in the forehead, a trickle of blood mixes with my tears, bathing my thighs,

minute particle born from deception, from shameless greed,
no less indifferent to its self than the heights of the sky,
and the purity of executioners, and explosions — cutting off
the cries.

I open a theater in myself
where a false slumber plays
a pointless trick
a disgrace that makes me sweat

no hope
death
the candle
blown out.

In the meantime, I read October Nights, *astonished to feel a lack of connection between my cries and my life. At heart, I am like Gérard de Nerval, happy with cabarets, with little nothings (more ambiguous?). I remember my taste for the villagers in Tilly at the beginning of the rains, the mud, the cold, the manly barmaids handling the bottles, and the noses (the schnozzes) of the big farmhands (drunk, and muddily booted); at night, the faubourg songs would cry from common throats, there were comings and goings of partying, and farts, and the laughter of girls in the courtyard. I was happy to listen to their life, scrawling in my notebook, laying in a dirty (and freezing) room. No shadow of ennui, happy with the warmth of their cries, and the spell of their songs: their melancholy gripped the throat.*

The Roof of the Temple

Feeling of a decisive battle from which nothing can deter me now. I am afraid, being certain that I will not avoid the battle anymore.

Would the answer not be: "that I forget the question"?

Yesterday, it seemed to me that I spoke to my mirror.

It seemed to me that I saw quite far away, as if by the glow of lightning, a region where anguish has led... a feeling brought on by a sentence. I have forgotten the sentence: it was accompanied by a perceptible change, like a clicking cutting the bindings.

I perceived a pulling back, as deceiving as that of a supernatural being.

Nothing's more detached from, nor more contrary to, malevolence.

Like remorse, I felt the impossibility of ever annulling my affirmations.

As if some intolerable oppression was holding us back.

Desire — trembling with it — that the chance, occurring, but imperceptible, in the uncertainty of the night, be seized nonetheless. And as strong as this desire was, I could only observe the silence.

Alone in the night, I remained reading, weighed down by this feeling of powerlessness.

I read all of Bérénice *(I have never read it). Only one sentence of the preface halted me: "...that majestic sadness which makes for all the pleasure of tragedy". I read* The Raven, *in French. I got up, contagiously affected. I got up and grabbed some paper. I recall the feverish haste in getting to the table: yet, I was calm.*

I wrote:

it advanced
a storm of sand
I cannot say that
in the night
she advanced like a wall of dust
or like the shrouded whirlwind of a phantom
she said to me
where are you
I had lost you
but I
who had never seen her
I screamed in the cold
who are you
madwoman
and why
pretend

not to forget me
at that moment
I heard the earth fall
I ran
I crossed
an endless field
I fell
the field also fell
an infinite sob the field and I
fell

empty starless night
void a thousand times extinguished
has such a scream
ever pierced you
such a long long fall.

At the same time, love was burning me. I was limited by words. I had exhausted myself with love in the void, as if in the presence of a desirable and undressed — but inaccessible — woman. Without even being able to express a desire.

Stupefication. Impossible to go to bed despite the hour, and the fatigue. Like Kierkegaard did a hundred years ago, I could have said about myself: "My head is as empty as a theater where a play has just been performed."

As I was staring at the void in front of me, a touch — immediately violent and excessive — joined me to that void. I saw that void and saw nothing, but it, the void, was embracing me.

My body was tense. It contracted as if, by itself, it might've had to reduce itself to the expanse of a point. One lasting flash was going from this inner point, to the void. I was grimacing and laughing, lips wide apart, teeth naked.

I Hurl Myself among the Dead

Night is my nudity
Stars are my teeth
I hurl myself among the dead
dressed in white sun

Death lives in my heart
like a little widow
she sobs she is cowardly
I am afraid I could vomit

the widow laughs herself silly
shredding the birds.

At my death
the horse teeth of the stars
neigh with laughter I *dead man*

shorn dead man
damp grave
one-armed sun

the grave-digger with teeth of a dead man
erases me

the angel flying raven-like
cries
        Glory to you!

I am the void of coffins
and the absence of myself
in the entire universe

the horns of joy
sound insanely
flashing bright the white of the sky

the thunder of death
fills the universe

too much joy
bends fingernails back.

I imagine
in the infinite depths
the deserted expanse
different from the sky I see
no longer containing those vacillating points of light
but torrents of flames
greater than a sky
blinding like the dawn

formless abstraction
striped with rifts
pile
of inanities of the forgotten
on one side the subject **I**
and on the other the object
universe shred of dead notions
where **I** crying throw out the debris
the lack of power
the hiccups
the discordant rooster-cries of ideas

oh nothingness manufactured
in the factory of infinite vanity
like a crate of false teeth

I bent over the crate
I want
to vomit want

oh failure
ecstacy from which I sleep
when I scream
you who are and will be
when I will no longer be
X deaf
giant mallet
breaking my head.

The sparkling
the heights of the sky
the earth
and I.

Star my heart spits you out

anguish beyond compare

I laugh but I am cold.

GLORIA IN EXCELSIS MIHI

From the highest heights of the sky,
the angels, I hear their voices glorify me.
I am, beneath the sun, a wandering ant,
small and black, a rolled stone
reaches me,
crushes me,
dead,
in the sky
the sun rages,
it blinds
I scream:
"it wouldn't dare!"
it dares.

Poems
not courageous
but softness
ear of delight
a ewe's howling voice
beyond goes beyond
torch extinguished.

God

With a hot hand
I die you die
where is he
where am I
without laughter
I am dead
dead dead dead
in the night of ink
arrow shot
at him.

Who am I
not "me" no no
but the desert the night the immensity
that I am
what is it
desert immensity night stupid
swift nothingness without return
and without having known anything
Death
answer
sponge dripping with dream
solar
plunge me in
so I won't know anything
more than these tears.

Star
I follow it
oh death
star of thunder
mad bell of my death.

From the Heights of Montserrat

Everything must return to the original fire
Flaming tempest
Thus spoke HÉRACLITUS
Dawn and dusk of man lucid and hard.
- You must see the ebb and flow
Of despicable passions.
- You will accept the damp just as we love
The mother who engendered us.
- Men and women, you are bound
To the fire of immaterial lava
Here and there; light, yet crushing

Always mortal
Always lively
Loving only what will come.

Always you are thrown to the volcanos of life and death.

And PARACELSUS: leaning on the sword
Of wisdom with both hands
Intimate with the stars and stones
In love with the caverns of man
The belly of the universe.

And you ZARATHUSTRA eye of light
At the center of a terrible and joyful world
I salute you from the heights
Of Montserrat.

Invocation to Chance

Oresteia
dew of the sky
bagpipe of life

spidered nights
of innumerable hauntings
relentless game of tears
oh sun in my breast the blade of a knife

rest yourself along my bones
rest yourself you are the lightning
rest yourself viper
rest yourself my heart

and let your assassin hair be free in the wind.



Chance oh pale deity
laughter of lightning
invisible sun
thundering in the heart
flashing
rip of bones

naked chance
chance in long white stockings
chance in a nightgown of lace.



madly
bones knotted
my heart is cold
my tongue is heavy.

The Discord

Ten hundred houses fall
hundred then a thousand dead
in the window of the heavens.

Belly open
head removed
reflection of long clouds
images of immense sky.

Higher
than the dark heights of the sky
higher
in a freakish opening
a gleaming trail
is the halo of death.

A heart of ice a steaming soup
a blood-stained foot
the moustache of tears
a death-rattle.

Flame of night
sawed-off leg
bare brains and bare foot
the cold the pus the cloud
and the brain blow blood.

I am hungry for blood
hungry for earth with blood
hungry for fish hungry for rage
hungry for garbage hungry for cold.

I am burning up with love
a thousand candles in my mouth
a thousand stars in my head

my arms become lost in shadow
my heart falls mouth to mouth
in the depths of death.

Night is my Nudity

Night is my nudity
Stars are my teeth
I hurl myself among the dead
dressed in white sun.



Death lives in my heart
like a little widow
she sobs she is cowardly

I am afraid I could vomit
the widow laughs herself to the sky
tearing open the birds.



I imagine
in the infinite depths
the vast expanse
different from the sky I see
no longer containing those vacillating points of light
but torrents of flame
greater than the sky
more blinding than the dawn
formless abstraction
striped with rifts
piles
of inanities of the forgotten
on one side the subject I
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shred of dead notions
where **I** crying throw out the debris

the impotence
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the discordant rooster-cries of ideas
oh nothingness manufactured
in the factory of infinite vanity
like a case of false teeth
I bent over the case
I want
to vomit living
oh my failure
ecstacy which sleepens me
when I cry out
you who are and will be
when I will no longer be
X deaf
giant mallet
smashing my head of night.

The Undifferentiated Being is Nothing

I

Hat
of felt
of death
the hoarfrost
the sister
of a sob
of joy

the whiteness
of the sea
and the pallor of light
will steal the bones

the absence
of death
smiles.

II

The body
of the crime
is the heart
of this delirium.

III

The laws of savoring
besiege
the tower of lust.

IV

The alcohol
of poetry
is the silence
deceased.

V

I have vomited
through my nose
the arachnoid sky
my whittled temples
made it thin
I am dead
and the lilies
evaporate the water
distilled

words lack

and in the end, I do too.

VI

The words of the poem, their indocility, their number, their insignificance, hold to the heart the impalpable instant, a kiss slowly pressed to the mouth of a dead woman, they hold the breath of that which no longer is.

The transparency of the beloved, miraculous indifference, what makes one lost, is lost in the infinite crystal of light: to never think of it again.

VII

Lightning kills
it rolls the eyes back
joy
erases
joy

erased
window of death
frozen
oh window
resplendent
with a shine which shatters
in the shadow which gathers

I am
what is not
I open

the mingled teeth
of the dead
and the creakings of light
which intoxicates me
with the embrace
which chokes
with water
which cries
from the dead air
and the soul of oblivion

but nothing
I see
nothing
I do not laugh anymore
for when I laugh too much
I become transparent.

I Gave to Limbour a Rendez-vous

I gave to Limbour a rendez-vous
on the Champs-Élysées
to speak of heaven

I said
heaven is a cat

a third said
heaven is two cats

another said
heaven is a tongue
thicker than a mob.

All the Way to the Boots in the Eyes

All the way to the boots in the eyes
all the way to the tears of mud
all the way to the hands swollen with pus
leads the path of defiance

from the long moans of the grave
where an airless death did whistle
and from the absence of hope
the star of the sky is born.

I was Dreaming of Touching the Sadness of the World

I was dreaming of touching the sadness of the world
on the disenchanted edge of an unknown swamp
I was dreaming of a heavy water where I would find
the lost paths of your deep mouth again

In my hands I felt a filthy animal
that escaped from the night of a hideous forest
and I saw it was the evil from which you were dying
which, laughing, I call the sadness of the world

a crazy light a burst of thunder
a laugh freeing your long nudity
an immense splendor finally illuminated me

and I saw your pain like charity
radiant in the night the long clear form
and the tomb-like cry of your infinity.

As I Die I Would Like to Hold

As I die I would like to hold
the object you will give to me
to squeeze it in my frozen hand
then soil it with my lips
with the spittle of the throes of death.

Dressed in my Bloody Sweat

Dressed in my bloody sweat
disheveled phantom of an old woman
the wind will freeze your teeth
and then I will kiss them
you will be dead.

The Deepness of a Night

The deepness of a night
buries in its dust
the great star Butchery
. . . . . .
the MILK of the sky.

Miscellaneous Notes on the Text

"Mademoiselle my Heart" (p. 2): This poem presents an interesting problem in translation. The French verb "maquiller" (meaning "to put make up on") is used as a past-tense adjective, which makes for an awkward translation because there is no easily recognizable English equivalent for this word. Thus, the word "cosmetic" was employed.

"With Romaine" (p. 4): This poem can be interpreted in multiple ways. Here are two more possibilities that should not be overlooked:

"For the Roman Woman"	"In the Roman Manner"
For the Roman woman a calf's heart	In the Roman manner the veal heart
the pointed beard and the rosy cock.	the pointy beard and the pink dick.

"Eliminated Poems" (p. 19): Though labeled poems, these works are constructed in the once-popular style of French dramatic dialogue in which inhuman objects express themselves through verse. In the case of "The Houses," the often repeated "Ten a hundred houses fall" stanza is introduced here. This stanza illustrates an example of Bataille's recycling mentioned in the "Introduction," and will appear again in the text of "The Discord" (p. 114), serving an entirely different function.

Also, the "Earth spin spin earth" stanzas (p. 32) have another possibility:

Earth turn turn earth
turning whores of wood
sun red sun black
roses white roses pink

roses of the grave
turning roses
whores of the grave
turning graves.

It is not known what text these "poems" were eliminated from.

"Erotic Poems" (p. 51): In "The Tolling" strophe, the verb "branler" (to toll) is also slang for masturbation. "Whacking off" or "wanking" could be just as easily substituted.

"The Archangelical" (p. 60): This is Bataille's epic poem in which he considers "the immensity" and his relationship to it. The "ass of ink" braying to the stars in the second section called "The Dawn" (see p. 72) could refer to the Nietschean donkey in *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, but it is much more likely that Bataille is aligning himself with Rimbaud who depicts himself as a pathetic/poetic ass in his poem "Bottom" from *The Illuminations*.

"I Hurl Myself among the Dead" (p. 100): Much of the imagery in this poem is recycled in "Night is my Nudity" (p. 116). The repeated parts function differently in each poem and also suggest other translating possibilities.

"I Gave to Limbour a Rendezvous" (p. 128): This poem was actually written in English by Bataille. Georges Limbour was a "rebel surrealist" and a close acquaintance of Bataille. Previously untitled, the title was taken from the first line and attributed to the poem by the translator.

"Mismatched Poems" (p. 129): "All the Way to the Boots in the Eyes," "I was Dreaming of Touching the Sadness of the World," "As I Die I Would Like to Hold," "Dressed in My Bloody Sweat," and "The Deepness of a Night" were published under the heading "Poèmes Disparates" in *L'Archangélique et autre poèmes* by Mercure de France in 1967 without any titles. Again, the titles have been attributed to the poems by the translator.

Sources

In Oeuvres complètes III (© Éditions Gallimard, 1971)

L'Archangélique
L'Orestie
La Discorde
Moi
Le Toit du temple
Je me jette chez les morts

In Oeuvres complètes IV (© Éditions Gallimard, 1971)

Douleur
Pipi
A la romaine
Rire
Mademoiselle mon coeur
Je mets mon vit
O Crâne
11 Poèmes retirés de l'Archangélique
Poèmes éliminés
Le Loup soupire
Poèmes érotiques
Coryphea
Mon chant
La Marseillaise de l'amour
La Valse brune
C'est la danse nouvelle
(Le trottoir de Danaïde)
La Tombe de Louis XXX
L'Oratorio

In Oeuvres complètes V (© Éditions Gallimard, 1973)

Gloria in excelsis mihi
Dieu

In L'Archangélique et autres poèmes (© Éditions Gallimard, 1967)

Du Haut de Monserrat
Invocation à la chance
La Discorde
La Nuit est ma nudité
L'Être indifférencié n'est rien
Poèmes divers

Translator Biography

Mark Spitzer grew up in Minneapolis where he attended the University of Minnesota and earned his Bachelor's Degree in 1990. He then moved to the Rocky Mountains and graduated with a Master's Degree in Creative Writing from the University of Colorado in 1992. After this, he lived on the road for quite a few years, then went to France to translate the poetry and posthumous plays of Jean Genet. He ended up living as Writer-in-Residence at the bohemian bookstore Shakespeare and Company in Paris, for two years, translating various works of French. His stories, essays, and poetry have appeared in many literary journals and magazines ranging from *Exquisite Corpse* to *Minnesota Monthly* to a book of poems called *En Délire*, published in France. His translation of *The Church* by Louis-Ferdinand Céline (co-translated with Simon Green) is forthcoming from Sun and Moon Press, as is his novel *Bottom-Feeder*, and a new translation of the poetry of Arthur Rimbaud entitled *From Absinthe to Abyssinia*, from Creative Arts Books. His chapbooks, *The Notch of the Sorceress* and *Motorhead*, are currently available through Bone World Publishing, New York, as is *Junkyard*, published by '58 Buick Press, Seattle. Mark Spitzer now lives in the Cajun swamps where he teaches English at the University of Southwestern Louisiana.

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Poetry

The Collected Poems of Georges Bataille

Translated with an Introduction by Mark Spitzer

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"Bataille's poetry oozes and spurts directly from his genitals. More than anyone except Rabelais and the bawdy folk imagination, he has set the genitals and its environs up on soapboxes to make speech. To catch this obscene, though often elegant ejecta, Mark Spitzer has set to work a fine ear. . . . The brilliant cloaka shimmers in his [renderings]." – Andrei Codrescu

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Georges Bataille is known primarily because of his controversial writings, such as his novel, *The Story of the Eye*, and his historical/philosophical work, *The Trial of Gilles de Rais*, as well as for his influential theoretical and philosophical works. All of these prose works have been translated into English but, except for a few pieces, not his poetry. This is the first collected English translation of his poetry. This is the poetry of a philosopher, but it is also a poetry with an obsessively erotic, often scatological edge, frequently pushing the boundary of what is or isn't obscene. As Bataille wrote in his *Eroticism: Death & Sensuality*, poetry "leads to the same place as all forms of eroticism – to the blending and fusion of separate objects. It leads us to eternity, it leads us to death, and through death to continuity. Poetry is eternity; the sun matched with the sea."

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